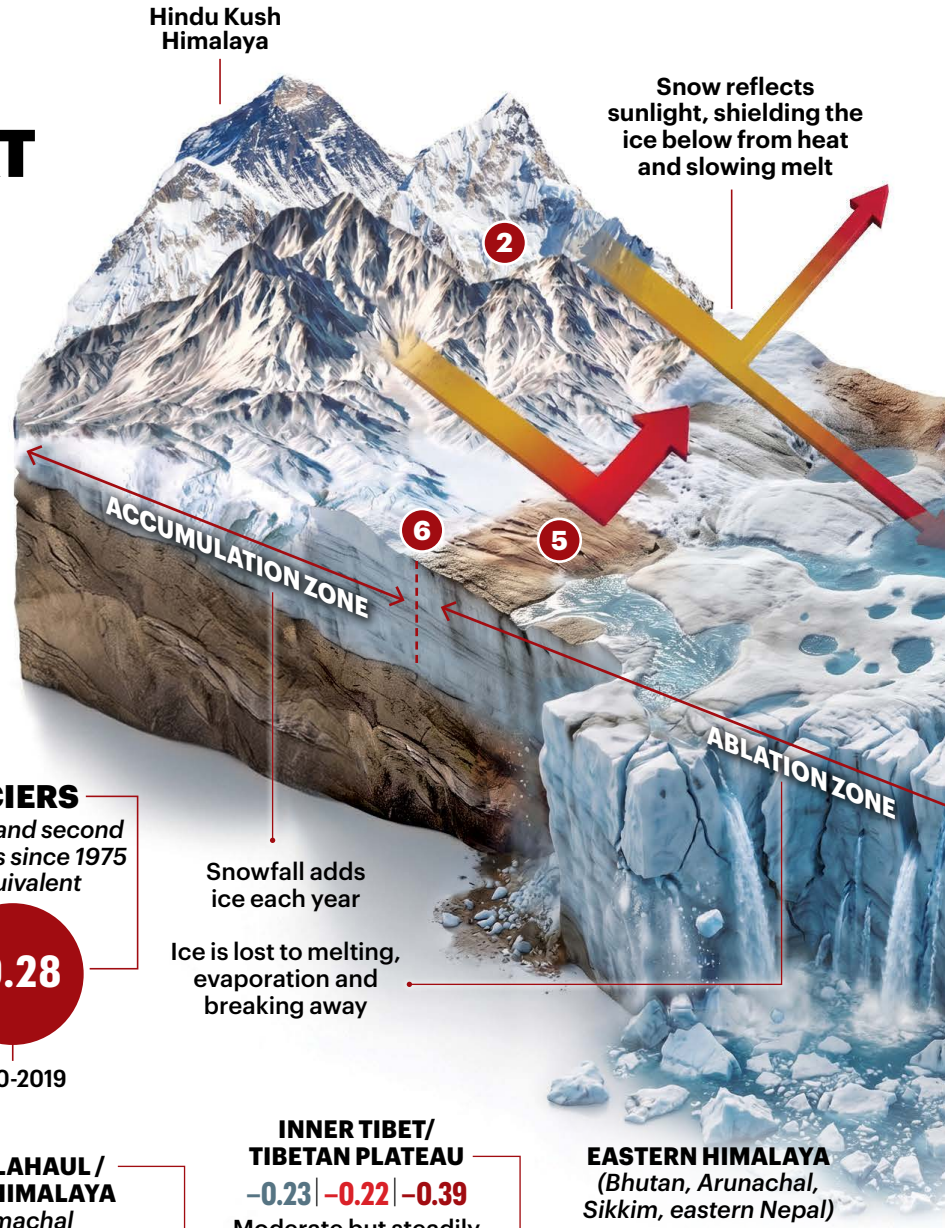
ENVIRONMENT

HIMALAYAN ICE IN RETREAT

Across the Hindu Kush Himalaya (HKH), glacier loss is accelerating sharply. Two recent studies by Nepal-based International Centre for Integrated Mountain Development warn that this will have serious consequences for nearly two billion people downstream. The HKH underpins water, food, energy and ecosystem security across the region. Often called the 'Water Tower of Asia', it spans eight countries from Afghanistan to Myanmar and holds the world's largest ice reserves outside the poles—hence the 'Third Pole'.

Graphic by **NILANJAN DAS**
Text by **JUMANA SHAH**



AVERAGE LOSS OF GLACIERS

Rate of loss rose 65% between the first and second decades of this century. Cumulative loss since 1975 reached –25 to -27 metres water equivalent

-0.12	-0.17	-0.28
1975-1999	2000-2009	2010-2019

KARAKORAM
(Pakistan/ India—largest glacier area)
–0.07 | –0.03 | –0.09
For much of the early 2000s, glaciers here were near-stable or even gaining mass. Now, they are losing ice

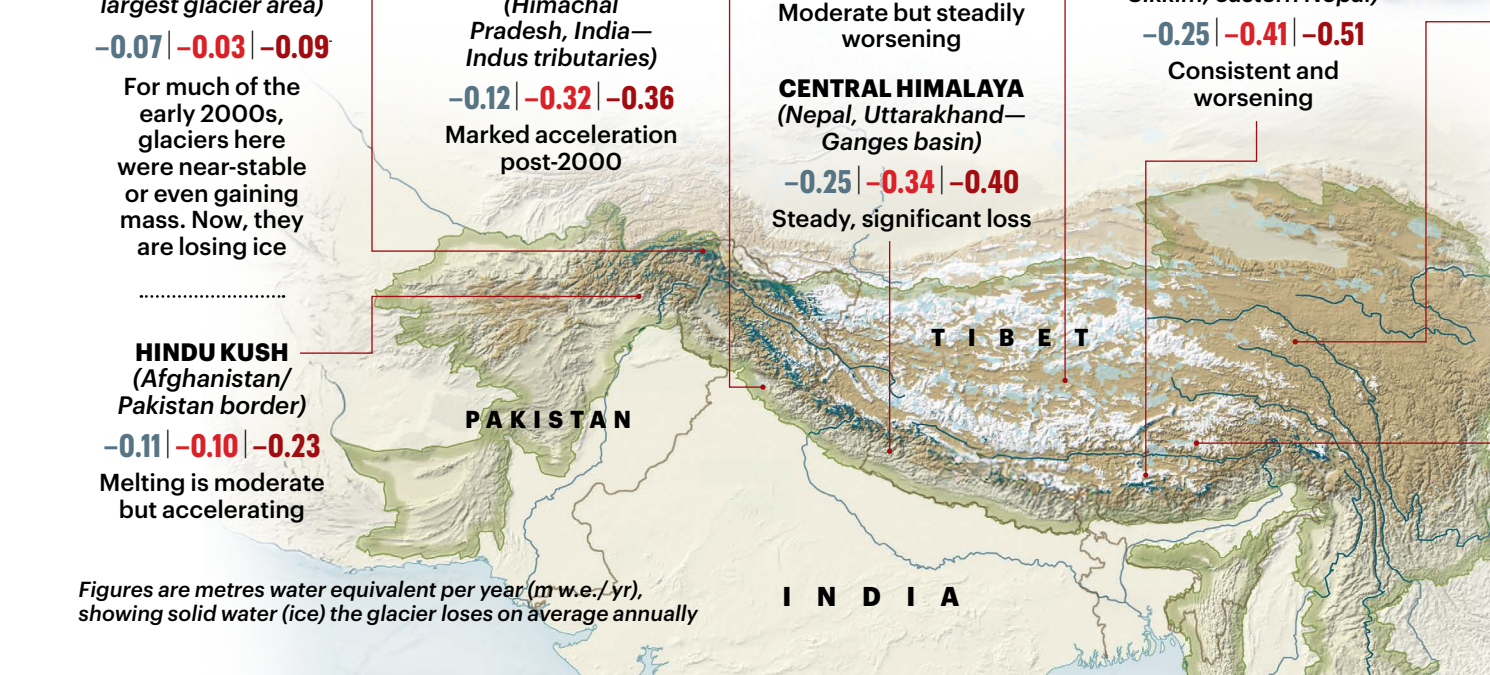
HINDU KUSH
(Afghanistan/ Pakistan border)
–0.11 | –0.10 | –0.23
Melting is moderate but accelerating

SPITI LAHAUL / WEST HIMALAYA
(Himachal Pradesh, India—Indus tributaries)
–0.12 | –0.32 | –0.36
Marked acceleration post-2000

INNER TIBET/ TIBETAN PLATEAU
–0.23 | –0.22 | –0.39
Moderate but steadily worsening

CENTRAL HIMALAYA
(Nepal, Uttarakhand—Ganges basin)
–0.25 | –0.34 | –0.40
Steady, significant loss

EASTERN HIMALAYA
(Bhutan, Arunachal, Sikkim, eastern Nepal)
–0.25 | –0.41 | –0.51
Consistent and worsening



Figures are metres water equivalent per year (m w.e./ yr), showing solid water (ice) the glacier loses on average annually